

Gifted Hands: **The Ben Carson Story**

Chapter by Chapter Comprehension Questions

Introduction by Candy Carson

1. What does the term *cardiovascular* mean?
2. What can you infer about the members of the surgical team and about the nature of the procedure itself from this quote: "Many of the 70-member team began offering to donate their own blood..."
3. What was unique about the procedure being attempted?
4. Who is the "ghetto kid from the streets of Detroit" referring to at the end of the introduction? What is his role in the procedure being attempted?

Chapter 1 - "Goodbye, Daddy"

1. How does Bennie feel about his father leaving them? How do you know? Be specific.
2. Complete the character chart about Sonya Carson (mother) and his father. Include quotes and details from Chapter 1 to support your idea.

Chapter 2 - "Carrying the Load"

1. How are Dr. Carson's parents similar? How are they different? Are they more different or more similar?
2. Write a compare/contrast paragraph describing the similarities and differences between Dr. Carson's mother and father.

Chapter 3 - "Eight Years Old"

1. What does Ben realize at the age of 8?
2. What is a missionary doctor? Use clues from the text.
3. How did Ben perform in school in 5th grade? Was this a surprising fact to learn?
4. How did Ben perceive his own academic abilities at that point in his life?
5. What do you think about the way Ben's teacher had the quizzes graded and scores recorded? Would you want your teacher to do the same? Why or why not?

6. What do you think the way Ben was treated in school did to his self-esteem?

Chapter 4 - "Two Positives"

1. What was wrong with Ben that was likely impacting his grades?
2. "Her constant interest and **unflagging** encouragement kept me motivated." Use context clues to determine the meaning of **unflagging**.
3. In what specific ways did Ben's mother force him to succeed?
4. (p. 37) How does Mrs. Carson feel about reading and books? Quote directly from the text and then explain the quote in *your own words*.
5. What part of math was impacted positively by Ben's increased reading?
6. What incident happened with Bobby Farmer that sparked the realization in Ben of his own abilities?

Chapter 5 - "A Boy's Big Problem"

1. What does "capping" mean?
2. Why did Ben need to change schools?
3. How did Ben deal with the constant "capping"?
4. Why was Ben's mother disappointed in him when he was in 10th grade? What does that tell you about her priorities?

Chapter 6 - "A Terrible Temper"

1. How does Ben describe his own temper?
2. How does Ben try to control his temper?
3. What verse from *Proverbs* does Ben read that rings true to him?
4. Describe 3 instances in which Ben loses his temper. Which surprises you the most?

Chapter 7 - "ROTC Triumph"

1. "We create our own destiny by the way we do things." What does Ben mean by this? Can you think of an example where the way you did things had an impact, positive or negative? How can you apply this quote in a positive way to your life?
2. On pages 64-65, Dr. Carson describes several people who influenced him during his high school years. Who are those individuals and what about them does Dr. Carson admire? Complete the chart with this information.

Chapter 8 - "College Choices"

1. What decisions, choices, and actions from Carson's life led to his having his choice of colleges to attend?
2. What harsh reality did Carson come to realize after just one week at Yale?

3. What miracle allowed Dr. Carson to ace the chemistry exam even though he had been failing?

Chapter 9 - "Changing the Rules"

1. What important lesson did Ben learn from his summer job at Ford?
2. What other jobs did Ben do over summer vacations from college? What lessons did he learn from those various jobs?
3. How did Ben eventually earn an extra ten dollars just for being honest?

Chapter 10 - "A Serious Step"

1. What qualities attracted Ben to Candy?
2. What natural gift (talent) did Ben realize he has when working a summer job at Sennet Street?
3. What is the reason Carson is often told he has "gifted hands"?

Chapter 11 - "Another Step Forward"

1. What is the foramen ovale? What did Ben decide to do when he watched a neurosurgeon try to find the foramen ovale in a patient during surgery?
2. How did the residents use Carson and his knowledge for their own benefit? How did Carson feel about being used this way?
3. How did Carson impress Dr. Udvarhelyi when interviewing for a coveted spot in the neurosurgery training program at Johns Hopkins?
4. How did Carson feel about the snobby behavior many doctors showed the other staff in the hospital? What did Carson do differently?

Chapter 12 - "Coming into My Own"

Define the following medical/technological terms:

- **Neurosurgery**
- **Oncology**
- **CT Scan, PET Scan, MRI**
- **Viable**
- **Mechanical disassociation (footnote on p. 124)**
- What mistake did hospital staff make concerning Carson's position in the hospital? Why did they make that mistake?
- How does Carson view the prejudice he experienced?
- What responsibility does Carson feel as a minority doctor?
- What advice does Carson give to minorities who are struggling to be accepted in the general population and achieve success?

Chapter 12 *continued*....

5. What decision did Carson have to make as a resident concerning an injured patient? Do you feel he made the right decision? What would you have done?

6. "We soon had high **viability**- almost 100 percent of cells survived." Using context clues, define **viability**.
7. "The rabbits uniformly died...., almost like clockwork." Why was this a positive thing?
8. Who does Carson give credit to concerning the quick development of his research technique? What does this tell you about Carson's personality?
9. What techniques and surgeries does Dr. Carson learn during that year at Hopkins?

Chapter 13 - "A Special Year"

1. What is apartheid?
2. What is the real reason Dr. Carson did not want to go to Australia for a year? What convinced him to change his mind?
3. What aspect of Carson's personal life allowed him and his wife to make so many friends immediately upon arriving in Australia? Do you have similar "family" association?
4. What is a craniotomy? (p. 132)
5. What does Carson believe he was able to achieve in Australia that he would likely not have been able to do in America? Why?
6. What dream did Carson achieve by the age of 33?

Chapter 14 - "A Girl Named Maranda"

Define the following Medical terms:

- **Hemispherectomy** (p. 145)
- **grand mal seizure**
- **epilepsy**
- **anticonvulsive medication**
- **nasogastric tube**
- **Rasmussen's encephalitis**
- What were the symptoms of the condition Maranda Francisco suffered from? What had her family already tried before turning to Dr. Freeman at Johns Hopkins Hospital?

Chapter 14 *continued*....

2. Describe the emotions Maranda's parents must have felt when they were told the risks of the surgery Dr Carson was recommending. What was the alternative?
3. What quotes from the text support your answers to #2?

Chapter 15 - "Heartbreak"

1. List the major steps Dr. Carson followed in performing the hemispherectomy. Then, write the steps in paragraph form, inserting transition words for coherence.
2. After completing the obscure surgery, Dr. Carson was filled with several unknowns. What were these uncertainties?
3. "The Franciscos had spent more than 10 hours in the waiting room..." What can you infer about the Franciscos from this quote?
4. What was extra special about Maranda's recovery?
5. What is plasticity and how does it allow patients like Maranda to triumph after a hemispherectomy?
6. How did Dr. Carson feel about media fanfare after the successful hemispherectomy? How did Carson demonstrate humility?

Chapter 15 *continued*....

7. What caused Dr. Carson to cry in public for the first time in his adult life? What

had he been unable to anticipate?
8. How was being a parent himself impacted Carson's relationship with the parents of his patients?

Chapter 16 - "Little Beth"

1. How did Beth's mother know to contact Dr. Freeman at Johns Hopkins concerning her daughter's excessive seizures?
2. What obscure procedure did Dr. Carson and Dr. Freeman propose? What about the interval between Beth's seizures led Beth's parents to refuse the procedure at first?
3. How were Beth's parents conflicted when the seizures' frequency increased? What eventually reinforced Dr. Carson's proposal of a hemispherectomy and altered Beth's parents' original decision?
4. What inner turmoil did Beth's parents deal with when Beth did not recover quickly?

Chapter 16 *continued*....

5. What is a tracheotomy? What ailment befell Denise Baca that resulted in her inability to breathe on her own?
6. What about Denise caused other doctors to believe a hemispherectomy was not a good idea?
7. The hemispherectomy proved invaluable to many patients, and Carson's successes reinforced his confidence. Why does Dr. Carson trust his own instincts and not give in to confrontation from other doctors?

Chapter 17 - "Three Special Children"

1. How did Dr. Carson succeed in restoring Bo-Bo to her robust, boisterous self? What is the name of the procedure and describe briefly what it involves?
2. Charles' mother did not allow Dr. Carson to perform surgery on her son because she was afraid the doctors were going to exploit her son's body without real hope of a recovery. What quotes from the text show how Charles' mother felt about her son's condition?
3. What is a cadaver? What does "cadaveric" mean? How was a cadaveric part used in Charles' surgery?
4. What character traits, do you think, motivated Dr. Carson to attempt to help Danielle and remove her destructible brain tumor? Why was the procedure not successful in saving Danielle?

Chapter 18 - "Craig and Susan"

1. What ritual did Dr. Carson share with Craig and Susan before he started operating on Craig?
2. Briefly describe the physical turmoil that had already befallen Craig from his rare ailment by the time he met Dr. Carson.
3. What is the pons? Why was it so likely that Craig wouldn't recover if the tumor was in the pons?

Chapter 19 - "Separating the Twins"

1. What news caused Theresa to plummet into depression when she was 8 months pregnant?
2. What typical development milestones would the twins be deprived of if they were not separated?
3. What is significant about this particular type of conjoined twins' separation surgery?
4. What unlikely event left Dr. Carson without a passport right before he was to travel to West Germany to perform surgery? How did this reinforce Carson's belief that a Divine Providence was guiding him?
5. After restarting the hearts of the twins, an anticipated, yet exasperating, problem arose. What was it, and how was it addressed?

Chapter 20 - "The Rest of Their Story"

1. What example does Carson share demonstrating how the media reported inaccurately about the twins, their surgery, and their recovery?

Chapter 21 - "Family Affairs"

1. What is unforeseeable about the job of a neurosurgeon and what toll does that take on Carson's personal life?
2. How does Carson distribute his time between his significant position in the hospital, his job as a father, and his capacity as a role model for others in his community?
3. What schedule did Carson devise to allow him time for role as a father?
4. How does Carson's past experiences with his own father impact the way he lives his life as an adult?